Contextualized English Speaking Through AI-Supported Visual Concept Construction: A Case of Lunar New Year Market Narratives

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Abstract: The purpose of this study is to enhance children's English speaking ability. Many children are reluctant to speak English. Their hesitation is not only due to concerns about grammatical errors; more often, they simply do not know how to describe a particular scene or what aspects of a situation are worth talking about. The difficulty does not necessarily stem from limited English proficiency. Instead, children frequently struggle to use appropriate spoken language to describe the details of a given context, whether in Chinese or English. For example, taking the Lunar New Year Market in Dadaocheng during the Year of the Horse as the theme, junior high school students were asked to describe in English the interesting events they experienced after visiting the market. When they attempted to speak, many encountered the problem of not knowing what to say. To address this issue, this study first asked students to draw the scenes that came to mind and that they intended to describe. Through visualization, students could first express the situations and the related people, objects, and events they wished to narrate in English. They were also encouraged to label their drawings with English keywords they already knew. Next, students organized the main people, objects, and events in their drawings into a concept map. The concept map was written in English, requiring students to indicate the relationships among concepts using English expressions. This process aimed to help them structure their ideas before engaging in oral production. ChatGPT was then integrated to support English speaking practice in three stages. In Stage One, students uploaded their drawings for image analysis. ChatGPT identified and annotated recognizable elements in the images with relevant English keywords, thereby expanding students' vocabulary for describing the scene. It also provided a list of these words along with translations. For instance, if a student had not written the English word for "旺," ChatGPT might generate feedback such as: "Prosperous (旺): meaning thriving or flourishing. This word is often associated with pineapple cakes, symbolizing good fortune." Students then practiced using these newly introduced or unfamiliar words. In Stage Two, ChatGPT categorized all identified vocabulary and generated a new concept map. This allowed students to see additional English words and phrases related to Dadaocheng beyond those in their original concept maps, helping them build associations among related terms in their minds. In Stage Three, ChatGPT provided example sentences relevant to the Dadaocheng context, such as: "Many visitors buy 'pineapple cake,' a popular Taiwanese souvenir, from the traditional bakeries in Dadaocheng." Students used these contextualized example sentences as models for English speaking practice. Through this ChatGPT-assisted mechanism, students were able to describe the Lunar New Year atmosphere in Dadaocheng using richer vocabulary and more elaborated sentences.

Keywords: AI-supported language learning, oral proficiency, concept map, visual aids